

I40

The centurion of Capernaum

A Gentile officer whose faith in Jesus' word made Jesus marvel.

The centurion of Capernaum was a military officer, a Gentile living among Jews in Galilee. Unusually, the local Jewish elders spoke well of him: he loved their nation and had built their synagogue. When a servant he valued lay sick and close to death, he asked Jesus for help. Yet he did not think himself worthy to have Jesus under his roof. As a soldier he understood authority, and he believed Jesus only had to give the word. Jesus marvelled and said he had not found such great faith in Israel. The servant was healed that same hour, a foretaste of the nations coming to Christ.

At a glance

Name	Not given in Scripture
Rank	Centurion, an officer over about a hundred soldiers
People	A Gentile who loved the Jewish nation (Luke 7:5, 9)
Home	Capernaum, on the north shore of the Sea of Galilee
Known for	Building a synagogue, and trusting Jesus to heal from a distance
When	c. AD 28–29, early in Jesus' ministry in Galilee
Main passages	Matthew 8:5–13; Luke 7:1–10

"The centurion answered and said, Lord, I am not worthy that thou shouldest come under my roof: but speak the word only, and my servant shall be healed."

Matthew 8:8, KJV

The life of The centurion of Capernaum

The date is approximate (AD) and follows the house chronology, with the crucifixion c. AD 30. Both Gospels place the story soon after Jesus' great sermon, when he returns to Capernaum.

Before Jesus came	● Builds a synagogue Stationed at Capernaum, the centurion comes to love the Jewish nation. He builds the town a synagogue, and the elders of the Jews speak warmly of him. <i>Luke 7:4-5</i>
c. AD 28-29 Capernaum	● His servant is dying A servant who is dear to him lies at home, sick of the palsy and grievously tormented, ready to die. Hearing of Jesus, he sends elders of the Jews to ask Jesus to come and heal him. <i>Matthew 8:5-6; Luke 7:2-3</i>
Near the house	● Speak the word only As Jesus comes near, the centurion sends friends with a message. He is not worthy for Jesus to enter his house. Like a soldier under orders, a word from Jesus will be enough. <i>Luke 7:6-8; Matthew 8:8-9</i>
The same hour	● Healed from a distance Jesus marvels and says he has not found so great faith, no, not in Israel. He says, "as thou hast believed, so be it done unto thee," and the servant is healed. <i>Matthew 8:10-13; Luke 7:9-10</i>

Group notes

Key activities

Matthew says the centurion came to Jesus himself. Luke says he sent Jewish elders and then friends. Many readers explain that people often spoke of someone doing what he did through messengers. Others see two ways of telling one story. John 4:46–54, about a nobleman's son, is usually treated as a different event.

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- 1 **Loved another nation.** Though a Gentile officer, he loved the Jewish people and built their synagogue. *Luke 7:4–5*
 - 2 **Cared for his servant.** He treated a sick servant as someone dear to him, not as property to replace. *Luke 7:2; Matthew 8:6*
 - 3 **Asked for help.** He sent respected Jewish elders to plead with Jesus on his behalf. *Luke 7:3–4*
 - 4 **Confessed his unworthiness.** The elders said he was worthy, but he said, "I am not worthy." *Luke 7:4, 6–7; Matthew 8:8*
 - 5 **Understood authority.** He said he was "a man under authority, having soldiers under me," and saw that Jesus' word had authority over sickness. *Matthew 8:9*
 - 6 **Amazed Jesus.** Jesus marvelled at him, which the Gospels record only here and at the unbelief of Nazareth. *Matthew 8:10; Luke 7:9; Mark 6:6*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names the centurion.

Old Testament

Echoes	Naaman, a Gentile army commander, is healed at a word through Elisha, without the prophet touching him (2 Kings 5:9–14). "He sent his word, and healed them" (Psalm 107:20). Many nations will come up to the mountain of the Lord (Isaiah 2:2–3).
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New Testament

Matthew 8:5–13	Jesus adds that many will come from the east and west and sit down with Abraham, Isaac and Jacob.
Luke 7:1–10	Luke tells of the elders' and friends' messages.
Echoes	Other centurions in the New Testament: the one at the cross who said, "Truly this man was the Son of God" (Mark 15:39); Cornelius, the first Gentile convert in Acts (Acts 10:1–48); and Julius, who treated Paul kindly (Acts 27:1–3, 43).

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did the Jewish elders say about the centurion, and what did he say about himself (Luke 7:4–7)?
2. *Understand:* What did the centurion understand about Jesus' authority that others missed?
3. *Apply:* The centurion used his position to help people outside his own group. How could you use your influence for someone different from you this week?
4. *Apply:* Where do you find it hard to trust God's word without seeing results first? Name one situation to pray about this week.